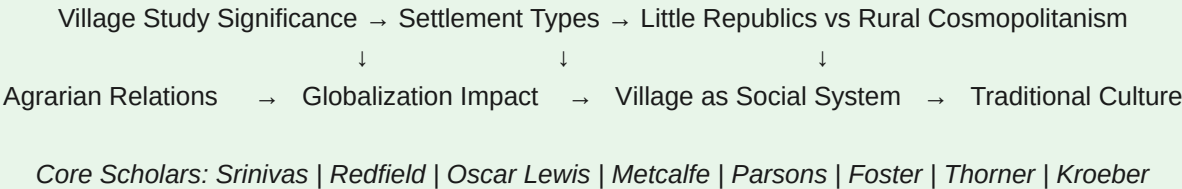


L-54 INDIAN VILLAGE

Anthropology Optional Paper 2 | Unit 5.1 | Sarrthi IAS Foundation | Nataraj Sir

Syllabus: Village study significance | Settlement patterns | Little Republics vs Rural Cosmopolitanism | Agrarian relations | Globalization impact | Village as Social System | Traditional Culture

INDIAN VILLAGE — TOPIC MAP



1. VILLAGE STUDY — SIGNIFICANCE

What is Village Study?

- In-depth investigation of **social, cultural, economic, political dynamics** of rural communities
- Methods: **Fieldwork + Participant Observation**
- Provides **holistic perspective** on tradition-modernity intersections

Views on Indian Villages

Thinker	View
Gandhi	"India lives in its villages" — autonomous, self-sufficient, moral
Nehru	Villages = backwardness, poverty, stagnation; future in industrialization
Ambedkar	"Sink of localism, den of ignorance, place of oppression" — caste discrimination

Key Scholars — Village Studies

Scholar	Contribution
Chicago School (Redfield, Singer, Marriot)	Theoretical & methodological foundations (1950s-60s)
Robert Redfield	Analytical concept of village India; Little & Great Traditions
William Wiser (1930s)	<i>Hindu Jajmani System; Behind the Mud Walls</i>
D.N. Majumdar	<i>Caste & Communication in an Indian Village</i> — transport impact on caste mobility
S.C. Dube	<i>Indian Village</i> — classic of village studies

Oscar Lewis

Rural Cosmopolitanism — villages NOT isolated

Significance — Theoretical Level

Concept	Scholar
Dominant Caste	M.N. Srinivas
Sanskritization & Westernization	M.N. Srinivas
Little Republics vs Rural Cosmopolitanism	Metcalfe vs Oscar Lewis
Little & Great Traditions	Robert Redfield
Universalization & Parochialization	McKim Marriot
Sacred Complex	L.P. Vidyarthi
Nature-Man-Spirit Complex	L.P. Vidyarthi

Significance — Applied Level (Policy)

Case 1: Community Development Programs (1950s)

If ₹1 crore given for development → went first to **dominant caste hamlets**. Roads, wells, electricity in upper caste areas; Dalit hamlets neglected. **Inequality grows despite schemes.**

Case 2: Tribal Sub-Plan (1974)

Funds meant for tribal communities captured by **non-tribal intermediaries** (contractors, moneylenders). Examples: Madhya Pradesh & Odisha.

Case 3: Barriers to Social Change

George Foster's "Traditional Culture": societies glorify past, resist change. Public toilets failed due to **caste prejudices** (refused to share). Co-education resisted due to **gender norms**.

UPSC Tip: Village studies bridged theory and practice — enriched anthropology with concepts (dominant caste,

Sanskritization) while guiding planners in rural development.

2. SETTLEMENT PATTERNS — TYPES & CHANGES

Factors Behind Settlement Types

Factor	Details
Physical	Altitude, climate, water. Himalayas → clustered in valleys; Rajasthan → scattered around oases
Cultural/Ethnic	Caste, religion. South India → around temples
Security	Raid-prone areas → clustered, fortified
Economic	Fertile plains → agrarian; coastal → fishing; market routes → trade

4 Types of Rural Settlements

Type	Features	Regions
1. Clustered / Nucleated	Compact houses; living area distinct from farms	Fertile alluvial plains, Bundelkhand, Nagaland, Rajasthan
2. Semi-Clustered	Fragmented — dominant caste in center, lower castes on flanks	Gujarat plain, parts of Rajasthan

3. Hamleted	Several units physically separated but common name (<i>panna, para, palli, nagla, dhani</i>)	Middle/lower Ganga plain, Chhattisgarh, lower Himalayas
4. Dispersed / Isolated	Isolated huts in remote jungles/hills; fragmented terrain	Meghalaya, Uttarakhand, HP, Kerala

Changes in Settlement Patterns

Factor	Change
Caste Dynamics	Caste-specific areas breaking down (awareness movements, govt policies)
Class & Economy	Land reforms, economic diversification → new settlement locations
Jajmani Decline	New industries → erosion of caste-based occupations
Social Mobility	Education → migration to urban/peri-urban areas
Modernization	Better transport, communication → movement from isolated areas
Govt Policies	Land redistribution, infrastructure → population shifts

3. LITTLE REPUBLIC vs RURAL COSMOPOLITANISM

Little Republics — Earlier Perception

Charles Metcalfe: Indian villages = "tiny republics, standing firm even when kingdoms rose and fell around them."

Henry Maine & Baden Powell: Also described villages as self-sufficient and autonomous.

Key Features of Metcalfe's Idea

- **Self-Sufficiency:** Own social, economic, political structures; managed agriculture + cottage industries
- **Political Independence:** Panchayat resolved disputes; reduced dependence on central authority
- **Social Cohesion:** Prevented concentration of power; fostered community solidarity

Supporting Examples

- **Panchayat System:** Local self-government — judicial + administrative
- **Traditional Economy:** Agriculture + cottage industries → village independence

Limitations

- Villages NOT completely isolated — engaged in trade, communication, cultural exchange
- **Nehru & Ambedkar critique:** Villages also sites of inequality, poverty, caste oppression

Rural Cosmopolitanism — Oscar Lewis

Oscar Lewis — studied **Rani Khera village (near Delhi)**

Key argument: Villages are NOT self-sufficient — maintain ties with other villages for social, cultural, economic, religious, and political activities.

Challenged: Metcalfe's Little Republic concept.

Mexico vs India — Lewis's Comparison (Chicago Seminar)

Mexico	India
Villages "inward looking"	Form complex network
No socio-cultural ties with other villages	Marriage, exogamy = social ties
Follow village endogamy	Economic ties (trade)
Inter-village network only for trade	Religious ties (pilgrimage)
	Political ties → "RURAL COSMOPOLITANISM"

Indian Examples of Rural Cosmopolitanism

1. **Jallikattu (Tamil Nadu):** Bull-taming during Pongal — participants from multiple villages → inter-village social bonds.
2. **Rath Yatras:** Jagannath Rath Yatra, Puri — pilgrims from various villages → shared religious identity.
3. **Village Fairs/Melas:** Annual fairs → cultural exchange, economic activities, social interactions across villages.

Conclusion: Indian villages are NOT isolated "little republics" but **dynamic, interconnected communities**. Villagers = active agents adapting and reshaping their societies.

4. AGRARIAN RELATIONS IN INDIAN VILLAGES

Definition

- Organization of rural life around **agriculture**
- Marked by: caste hierarchies, land ownership/tenancy, gender inequalities
- Land concentrated in few hands; most are tenants/laborers

Two Components of Agrarian Structure

- **Technological arrangements** — machinery, tech for agriculture
- **Social arrangements** — power structure, land ownership, control
- *Relationship*: ↑ Technology → ↓ Reliance on social arrangements (and vice versa)

Peasant Society — A.L. Kroeber

A.L. Kroeber: Peasant society = "**part society**" — signifying reliance on larger society across technological, economic, political, administrative, religious, and moral spheres.
Social structures intricately woven into caste and class relationships.

Daniel Thorner's Classification (3 Parts)

Category	Local Term	Description
Proprietors/Landowners	Malik	Rich upper-caste; held dominant power (Zamindars, Jagirdars)
Working Peasants/Tenants	Kisan	Middle castes; small owners/tenants; "backbone of cultivation"
Agricultural Laborers	Mazdoor	Landless lower castes; dependent

		on wages/sharecroppir
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D.N. Dhanangre (1983) — Extended Classification

D.N. Dhanangre — drew from **Lenin & Mao's** analysis of agrarian classes:

1. **Landlords** — large landowners, not cultivating
2. **Rich peasants** — enough land to hire laborers
3. **Middle peasants** — small plots, family labor
4. **Poor peasants** — very small plots, dependent
5. **Landless laborers** — no land, daily wages

Noted: Social composition (castes, religious/ethnic groups) too complex to reduce to simplistic formulae.

Caste-Class Links in Agrarian Society

Agrarian Class	Caste Groups
Landlords/Rich (non-cultivating)	Brahmin, Thakur, Bania (N. India); Kamma, Reddi, Rao (AP); Okkaliga, Lingayat (Karnataka); Patidar (Gujarat); Kunbi Maratha (MH)
Middle/Poor Peasantry	Traditional cultivator & artisan castes; largely debt-burdened
Landless Laborers	Predominantly SCs / untouchable castes

Changes in Agrarian Structure

Change	Details
Land Reforms	Redistribution; more small/marginal farmers; reduced landlord influence
Tenancy Patterns	Better protection for tenants, improved credit access
Caste Hierarchies	Social mobility via education; caste influence declining
Gender	Women's participation improved via govt policies

5. IMPACT OF GLOBALIZATION ON INDIAN VILLAGES

Anthony Giddens: Globalization = "The gradual integration of economies and societies across the world."

Pre-Globalization Village

- Centers of **self-sufficiency + collectivism**
- Pre-literate economic methods
- Jajmani system** = dominant economic arrangement
→ social relations between castes

Impacts of Globalization

#	Impact	Scholar/Study	Key Point
1	Village Economy Trends	A.R. Desai	4 trends: subsistence → surplus; modern tech; abolition of intermediaries; new institutions
2	Agrarian Relations Change	Chand & Srivastava (2014) — Jamgod, MP	Shift from traditional to contract-based employment

3	Depeasantization	Tilche — Patidars, Sundarana, Gujarat	Education + emigration; farming no longer status marker
4	New Conflicts	Simpson (2016)	Agri vs non-agri conflicts; decline of jajmani; reduced Sanskritization appeal
5	Joint Family Disruption	Iravati Karve	Weakening of joint family ties
6	Jajmani Decline	William Wiser (defined)	State role, tech innovations, political mobilization → decline
7	Cultural Erosion	—	Westernization through global med erodes traditional values
8	Agriculture Change	—	Mechanization benefits big rich farmers ; rapid migration

UPSC Key: Impact is multifaceted — agrarian transformation, depeasantization, new conflicts, disruption of traditions, decline of Jajmani.

6. INDIAN VILLAGE AS A SOCIAL SYSTEM

Definitions

- **System:** Orderly arrangement; inter-relationship of parts with fixed place and definite role
- **Social System:** "Patterned series of interrelationships between individuals, groups, and institutions forming a coherent whole"

Talcott Parsons: "Social system consists of a plurality of social actors engaged in more or less stable **interaction** according to **shared cultural norms and meaning**."
→ Interaction is 'patterned interaction'
→ Takes under orbit all sub-systems: economic, political, religious

5 Features of Social System (Parsons)

Feature	Village Example
Plurality of Actors	Different castes, occupations, age groups
Aims & Objectives	Social harmony, cultural preservation, well-being
Order & Pattern	Economic, political, religious subsystems coexist in structured way
Functional Unity	All activities contribute to overall stability
Maintenance	Socialization (cultural transmission) + Social control (rule enforcement)

3 Subsystems of Indian Village

INDIAN VILLAGE — SOCIAL SYSTEM

Caste-Jajmani (Economic-Ritual) | **Panchayati Raj** (Political) | **Joint Family** (Socialization)

All three fulfill: Plurality → Aims → Order → Functional Unity → Maintenance

1. Caste & Jajmani System (Economic-Ritual Subsystem)

- **Plurality:** Different castes in constant interaction
- **Order:** Caste hierarchy gives fixed order; Jajmani defines service exchange
- **Functional Unity:** Interdependence (barber cuts hair → farmer gives grain)

2. Panchayati Raj (Political Subsystem)

- **Aims:** Local governance, justice, development
- **Order:** Democratic rules, elections, dispute resolution
- **Maintenance:** Social control via panchayats

3. Joint Family (Socialization Subsystem)

- **Plurality:** Many generations interact daily
- **Functional Unity:** Role division (elders guide, adults earn, children learn)
- **Maintenance:** Socialization of children, transmission of culture

Conclusion: Indian village = cohesive social system; within larger Indian society, it acts as a **subsystem**. Exhibits all 5 Parsonian features.

7. TRADITIONAL CULTURE — George Foster

George Foster (American anthropologist)

Fieldwork: **Mexico (Latin America)**

Definition: "Cultural practices and beliefs **transmitted from one generation to the next**, creating continuity and stability in society."

Key Features

Feature	Detail
Stability & Coherence	Preserved through oral transmission (songs, rhymes, rituals); follow forefathers' path
Identity & Continuity	Festivals, fairs reinforce values; sense of belonging
Adaptiveness	May adapt slowly; change resisted if threatens core values

Traditional Culture as BARRIER to Social Change

Indian Examples

1. Caste System: Rigid social segregation; controls interaction, marriage, residence. Higher castes control resources; limits social mobility. Dalits excluded from wells, temples.

2. Sanitation Practices:

Dean Spears & Michael Geruso (2018): Hindus far less likely than Muslims to use toilets at same income. Belief: open defecation away from home = "purer." → High child mortality. **Swachh Bharat Abhiyan** challenged by this cultural barrier.

3. Caste Segregation — Karnataka 📍:

Naveen Bharathi et al. (2020): Intra-village segregation

> black-white segregation in American South.

Spate & Learmonth (1954): Residential space mirrors caste hierarchy.

Example — Amminabhavi (Dharwad): Dalits → periphery; dominant castes → center; worker castes → margins; headman controls best land.

4. Child Marriage: Family honor/purity → girls married young. Restricts education, increases health risks. Persists despite legal prohibition.

5. Female Infanticide: Preference for male children (lineage, last rites, dowry burden of daughters) → distorted sex ratio → barrier to gender equality.

Global Examples

- Gender roles in rural Africa → limit women's education
- Resistance to Western medicine among indigenous groups
- Resource use in tribal South America vs conservation laws

Criticism of Foster

- Too **simplistic** — assumes cultures are static
- Overlooks traditions as **dynamic, evolving, negotiable**
- Can justify "cultural purity" and exclusion of minorities

*"Culture can be seen as both a **shield** that protects communities and a **wall** that obstructs progressive change unless addressed with sensitivity." — Conceptual conclusion on Foster*

CURRENT HOOKS — Recent Developments (2025-26)

1. Budget 2025-26 — Rural Development: Rs 1,88,754 crore allocated for 6.65 lakh villages; Jal Jeevan Mission extended to 2028; 12.2 crore households with tap water (Jan 2025). MGNREGS expanded to 125 days/year.

2. Vibrant Villages Programme-II (April 2025): Central Sector Scheme for 1,954 villages on international borders across 15 states + 2 UTs.

3. Poverty Decline (MPI 2025): Multidimensional poverty declined 24.85% → 14.96% (2015-16 to 2019-21); 13.5

crore escaped poverty.

4. Caste Segregation Persists (2025): 113 caste atrocity incidents recorded Jan-Jun 2025 (UP: 34, MP: 15). Residential segregation still mirrors caste hierarchy in villages.

5. Rural Urbanization Study (Nijman et al., 2026): Traditional power relations of class and caste shape emergent urbanizing landscapes in rural India — 65% population still rural.

KEY QUOTES — Use in Mains Answers

Gandhi: "India lives in its villages."

Ambedkar: "A sink of localism, a den of ignorance, and a place of oppression."

Metcalf: Indian villages = "tiny republics, standing firm even when kingdoms rose and fell."

Kroeber: Peasant society = "part society."

Parsons: "Social system consists of a plurality of social actors engaged in more or less stable interaction according to shared cultural norms and meaning."

Giddens: "The gradual integration of economies and societies across the world."

Naveen Bharathi et al.: Intra-village segregation in Karnataka > black-white segregation in American South.

Foster (conceptual): Culture = both a "shield" and a "wall."

GOVERNMENT SCHEMES — Summary Table

Scheme / Policy	Year	Relevance to Village Studies
Community Development Programs	1950s	Rural development; village studies showed dominant-caste capture
Tribal Sub-Plan	1974	Tribal development; non-tribal intermediaries captured benefits
Land Reforms	Post-1947	Changed agrarian social structure; reduced Zamindar power
Panchayati Raj (73rd Amendment)	1992	Political subsystem of village; local self-governance
Swachh Bharat Abhiyan	2014	Sanitation; cultural beliefs as barrier
Jal Jeevan Mission	2019 (ext. 2028)	Tap water to all rural HHs — settlement/development change
MGNREGS (125 days)	2006/2025	Rural employment guarantee; shifts agrarian labor relations
Vibrant Villages Programme-II	2025	Border village development — 1,954 villages

QUICK REVISION CHEAT SHEET

Topic	Main Points (Keywords)	Key Scholars	Examples	Key Case Studies
Village Study — Significance	Fieldwork, participant observation; holistic; theoretical + applied significance; dominant caste capture of development funds	Srinivas, Redfield, Wiser, S.C. Dube, Majumdar, Oscar Lewis, Vidyarthi, Marriot	CDP funds → dominant caste hamlets; Tribal Sub-Plan capture in MP/Odisha	Community Development Blocks (1950s); Tribal Sub-Plan (1974)
Settlement Patterns	4 types: Clustered, Semi-clustered, Hamleted, Dispersed; factors: physical, cultural, security, economic; changes due to caste decline, mobility, modernization	—	Bundelkhand (clustered); Gujarat (semi-clustered); panna/dhani (hamleted); Kerala/Meghalaya (dispersed)	South India temple-based settlements; Rajasthan oasis settlements
Little Republics vs Rural Cosmopolitanism	Metcalfe: self-sufficient, autonomous; Lewis: interconnected, ties (social/economic/religious/political); Mexico vs India comparison	Metcalfe, Maine, Baden Powell, Oscar Lewis	Jallikattu (TN); Rath Yatra (Puri); Village melas	Rani Khera village study (Lewis)
Agrarian Relations	Caste-class link; Malik-Kisan-Mazdoor; "part society"; 5-class system; tech vs social arrangements; land reforms changed structure	Kroeber, Daniel Thorner, D.N. Dhanangre, Lenin, Mao	Zamindars/Jagirdars (Malik); SC landless laborers; regional caste-class (Kamma, Patidar, Okkaliga)	Agrarian class composition varies by region — too complex for formulae (Dhanangre)
Globalization Impact	Subsistence → surplus; contract labor; depeasantization; jajmani decline; joint family disruption; mechanization benefits rich; cultural erosion	Giddens, A.R. Desai, Chand & Srivastava, Tilche, Simpson, Iravati Karve, Wiser	Jamgod village MP (contract labor); Sundarana Gujarat (Patidar emigration)	Chand & Srivastava 2014; Tilche — Patidars; Simpson 2016
Village as Social System	Parsons: 5 features (plurality, aims, order, functional unity, maintenance); 3 subsystems: Caste-Jajmani, Panchayat, Joint Family; patterned interaction	Talcott Parsons	Jajmani exchange (barber → farmer); Panchayat dispute resolution; Joint family role division	—
Traditional Culture	Foster: transmitted beliefs; stability, identity, adaptiveness; BARRIER: caste, sanitation, child marriage, female infanticide, segregation; criticism: too static	George Foster, Spears & Geruso (2018), Naveen Bharathi et al. (2020), Spate & Learmonth (1954)	Amminabhavi (Karnataka segregation); Swachh Bharat vs open defecation; child marriage despite laws	Karnataka segregation > American South; Sanitation study (same income, different behavior)

MEMORY AIDS — Mnemonics

Views on Villages (GAN): Gandhi (glory) | Ambedkar (oppression) | Nehru (backwardness)

Settlement Types (CSHD): Clustered | Semi-clustered | Hamleted | Dispersed

Thorner's 3 Classes (MKM): Malik | Kisan | Mazdoor

Parsons' 5 Features (PAOFM): Plurality | Aims | Order | Functional Unity | Maintenance

3 Subsystems (CJP): Caste-Jajmani | Joint Family | Panchayat

Globalization Impacts (DCJAM): Depeasantization | Contract labor | Jajmani decline | Agri-nonagri conflict | Migration